

DUNLIN

Calidris alpina

Habitat: Wetlands of Haryana

Reason for decline: Not clear

HIGH

LOST IN MIGRATION

TREND: India is a key non-breeding destination for many Eurasian bird species. The decline in the number of long-distance migrants has been significant, over 50 per cent. Shorebirds that breed in the Arctic have been particularly affected, declining by close to 80 per cent as a group. By comparison, resident species as a group have remained much more stable.

WHY: Conservation of long-distance migrants requires identifying and maintaining the health of critical habitats, including intertidal mudflats, mangroves, grasslands, open wetlands, paddy fields and reedbeds. This ensures they are able to feed and build up resources for their arduous migration journeys.



"We have a moral obligation to protect birds. Not only because we must make space for all life, but also because we enjoy birds"

– V. SANTHARAM *Ornithologist and director, Institute of Bird Studies & Natural History at Rishi Valley*

as the 'mad babul' in India, has turned arid and semi-arid regions in Tamil Nadu, Gujarat, MP, NCR and Rajasthan unsuitable for open habitat-dwellers. In the high altitude grasslands of the Western Ghats, some planted exotic trees like the wattle have now turned invasive, threatening the future of birds like the Nilgiri pipit (*Anthus nilghiriensis*).

Mrugank Prabhu, a researcher and ornithologist with the BNHS, has been studying migratory populations in Mumbai for over a decade now. He explains why specialist birds—those loyal and acclimatised to one ecosystem or dependent on one region for breeding—are the most threatened. "It is a Y-shaped journey—the birds breed in a huge area in Arctic Russia, but as they go down the letter, they are all channelled through a small route to a smaller area to feed in the winter. They come to the same place for life. If anything happens to these places, they can't adapt. The flamingo's beak, for example, is designed to feed on algae. If it can't find algae, it'll die out," says Prabhu.

DILEMMA OF THE MIGRATORY BIRDS

Nearly 370 species of migratory birds visit India through three flyways—the Central Asian Flyway (CAF), the East Asian-Australasian Flyway (EAAF) and the Asian-East African Flyway (AEAF). Over 80 per cent of the birds come through CAF and, of these, 87 species are of high conservation concern, two critically endangered, five endangered and 13 vulnerable among them. The Indian coastline is an important wintering zone for them. If the refuelling and feeding grounds of these birds are taken over, the birds will not know where to find food or water.

The availability of food resources, in fact, greatly affects the avian population. Birds feed on a variety of food—vultures and other raptors feed primarily on meat, others rely on fruits and nectar, yet others on seeds, and some on invertebrates. Crows eat more than one type of food, and are omnivores. SoIB 2023 points out that birds that feed on vertebrates and carrion have declined the most. "Either the food resource contains harmful pollutants, or is declining in availability, or both," says Prabhu.